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College Students' Intention to Volunteer for Non-profit Organizations: Does Brand Image Make a Difference?

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ABSTRACT

Non-profit organizations (NPOs) are still struggling to recruit volunteers. While the impact of the organizational brand image on recruitment has been investigated in for-profit organizations, there is a dearth of similar studies in non-profit settings. Addressing this problem, this quantitative study examines the effect of NPOs' brand image, including brand personality as the symbolic function and recognition reward as the instrumental function, on the intention to volunteer for college students. The results from 133 participants showed a significant difference in the intention to volunteer between participants exposed to NPOs with certain brand personalities and NPOs with no brand personalities at all. A significant difference was also found between participants offered recognition reward and those who were not. These results indicate the importance of brand image in increasing volunteering intention, which informs NPO practitioners to create better strategies to increase their success in recruiting volunteers.

KEYWORDS

Brand personality; college students; intention to volunteer; organizational brand image; recruitment; recognition reward

Introduction

Despite their noble vision to change the world or make the world a better place, non-profit organizations (NPOs) are still struggling to recruit volunteers. The volunteering positions are usually driven by charitable mission, have no monetary compensation, and offer no career opportunities. In other words, the nature of the jobs in NPOs are unpaid with a short-term commitment to the organizations. With these characteristics, NPOs already have disadvantages as they have little benefits to offer compared to for-profit organizations.

Data from the U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics (2016) shows that volunteer rate in the USA slightly decreases by the end of 2015 compared to 2011. There is a consensus among scholars that there is increasing competition in nonprofits' environment (Weerawardena, McDonald, & Mort, 2010). Growth

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in nonprofit organizations leads to intensive competition for scarce resources, including the volunteers (Bussell & Forbes, 2002).

This is unfortunate because volunteers are critical for the organizations. Not only they help carrying out the daily activities, but they also help spreading the message or mission statement of the organizations. Finkelstein (2008) even argued that nonprofit organizations would not survive without the assistance of volunteers. Additionally, they are more likely to make charitable gifts (Farrow & Yuan, 2011). Getting more volunteers would mean greatly not only for the NPOs but also for the society, as they contribute to the continuation of the good deeds delivered by the organizations.

Furthermore, a study by Ntamere (2012) showed a significant correlation between volunteer numerical strength and nonprofits' sustainability. This means that the adequate number of volunteers can make the organization more sustainable. Since volunteers play such an important role, the researcher suggested that strategic positioning through strategic volunteer recruitment and management is important to give nonprofits sustainability leverage. Because of this significance, an adequate recruitment strategy to attract volunteers is more than necessary for non-profit organizations.

Past research showed that organizational attraction was strongly influenced by the applicant's perceptions of job and organizational characteristics such as pay, advancement and career opportunities, or organizational structure (Cable & Graham, 2000; Lievens, Decaesteker, Coetsier, & Geirnaert, 2001). However, they are not the only attributes that influence the applicants. Their initial attraction to the organization is also based on the symbolic meanings that they associate with the organizations, including the person-descriptive trait inferences associated with organizations, or brand personalities (Aaker, 1997). Borrowing instrumental-symbolic framework from marketing literature, Lievens and Highhouse (2003) confirmed that both attributes form the brand image, a critical aspect of the organizational attraction, defined as a mental representation of the organization based on individual applicant's beliefs, ideas, and impression (Malik, Naeem, & Munawar, 2012).

A number of researches have been done in an attempt to investigate the relationship between organizational brand image and how they affect organizational attractiveness from the perspective of employee recruitment (e.g., Cable & Turban, 2001; Lievens & Highhouse, 2003; Slaughter et al., 2001). However, the aforementioned relationships in nonprofit settings are rarely explained. There is lack of research explaining how brand image, including the instrumental and symbolic function of the organizational brand, might affect the applicants to volunteer for nonprofit organizations.

In order to address this limitation, this study is proposed to examine the effect of the brand image, constitutes both the symbolic and the instrumental

aspects, on the intent to volunteer. More specifically, the study will investigate this topic on college student populations in The United States, considering they are one of the main targets for recruitment activities (Berthon, Ewing, & Hah, 2005). It is also necessary to investigate the effect of brand image on these demographic characteristics because according to The US Bureau of Labor Statistics (Bls.gov, 2016), there are not many people volunteering in this group (16–24 years old), compared to Caucasian women age 35 to 54 years old as the group who are more likely to volunteer. The results of the study will inform practitioners in nonprofit settings about the influence of both symbolic and instrumental aspects on the intention to volunteer so that they are able to make a stronger strategy to increase their success rate on recruiting volunteers.

Literature review

NPOs' brand image in recruiting volunteers

Unlike profit-oriented organizations, nonprofit organizations do not aim to generate and share profit (Wolf, 1999). They are driven by certain missions to increase critical and visible position in political, social, and economic life (Frumkin, 2002). Obiyan (2006) explained that the goal of nonprofit organizations is to alleviate the suffering of the poor or the disadvantaged group, not only by providing their needs but also by challenging them to engage in participatory and collaborative solution to their problems. Therefore, the main focus of nonprofits organizations is not to gain profit but to make life easier for the people in need.

In order to achieve their missions, nonprofit organizations rely on the volunteers as one of the most important contributors. The ability to recruit the correct persons suited for the volunteering roles is vital (Lysakowski, 2002). Successful volunteer attraction and recruitment require carefully planned activities that will put into consideration the problem of time constraint, skills and talents required, and the provision of volunteers' needs (Volunteer Canada, 2001, as cited in Ntamere, 2012).

Bowen et al. (2001) strongly believed that perception of an organization is a significant part of the attractiveness tied to the recruitment of volunteers. The perception of the organization can be explained by the concept of the brand image. Research views brand image as a collection of ideas, feelings, and attitudes that consumers have about brands (Gardner & Levy, 1955; Schmitt, 2012). More specifically in an organizational setting, Lievens (2007) defines an organizational brand image as people's global impression that is based on loose structures of knowledge and beliefs about the organization. He explained that image is the product of the cognitive reactions and associations of customers, investors, employees, and applicants to an organization's name. Images may change due to organizational behavior

including how it shares and presents information to the public through the media, advertising, and corporate websites.

Lievens (2007) identifies two general components of the organizational brand image. First, the instrumental attributes, which are usually a group of objective attributes that people associate with any organization. Job/organizational characteristics play an important role as the instrumental attributes, such as salary, incentives, benefits, positions, career opportunities, organizational structure, size, and work location (Cable & Graham, 2000; Lievens et al., 2001). However, job/organizational characteristics are probably less useful in early stages because there is limited information about the differences among organizations to be perceived (Lievens & Highhouse, 2003).

The second component is the symbolic attributes, which are trait-related inferences from an organization. Compared to instrumental attributes, symbolic attributes are different in a way that they are subjective, abstract, and intangible (Lievens, 2007; Lievens & Highhouse, 2003). They also help to convey the personalities that people assign to organizations (Aaker, 1997), which play a key role in the overall perception of the image that influences the types of individuals attracted to the organization.

According to Keller (1993), the positive brand image directly impacts brand equity and consumer behavior, and this transcends to the nonprofit context. Chiagouris (2005) claimed that an attractive brand image is more important for organizations in nonprofit settings compared to commercial companies and that an effective one can significantly increase numbers of donors, members, and volunteers. It has also become the integral part of a nonprofit organization's promotional activities, through its ability to shape the volunteer candidates' attitudes toward the organization and to influence their actions, including their intention to apply for volunteering activities (Bendapudi, Singh, & Bendapudi, 1996).

In constructing certain images, recruitment activities are very important. Recruitment is a series of efforts carried on by an organization with the primary purpose of identifying and attracting potential employees, starting with identifying an appropriate pool of applicants, persuading them to pursue and ultimately accept employment after going through several selection processes (Barber, 1998). In regards to nonprofit organizations, the recruitment activities aim to attract volunteers. A variety of recruitment methods are used by nonprofits to recruit volunteers, such as informal word of mouth and promotion by the existing members, or formal recruitment efforts such as advertisement on local media, posters and leaflets, notice boards, or online media including email and social networking sites (Connolly, 2014; Roach, 2013).

Chapman, Uggerslev, Carroll, Piasentin, and Jones (2005) conducted a meta-analytic study to evaluate the impact of recruitment practices on applicant attraction and job choice behavior. The study showed the

importance of organizational brand image ($\rho = .48$) as predictor of organizational attraction. Marketing research has consistently shown that organizational brand images are easily recognizable, influence the attraction of job applicants to organizations, and serve to unify and embed employees within an organization (Allen, Mahto, & Otondo, 2007; Scott & Lane, 2000; Siguaw, Mattila, & Austin, 1999). Research also showed that the brand image has a significant effect on the applicant's intention to apply, a decision during recruitment and that companies with a strong brand image would be preferred over those with weak or negative brand image (Cable & Turban, 2001; Lemmink, Schuijf, & Streukens, 2003).

It is suggested that organizational branding is an effective recruitment practice. It allows the organizations to highlight specific attributes that will be perceived by the volunteer candidates. By utilizing both instrumental and symbolic attributes in the recruitment processes, nonprofits can shape the organizational brand image in order to attract more volunteers.

Recognition reward as the instrumental attributes

Motivations to volunteer have been explained in terms of altruism and egoism. Kottasz (2004) argued that egoistic motivation might be associated with tangible recognition, physical outputs, and compensation expectations. Many studies have found a correlation between effective volunteer management programs, including recognition activities, and the efficacy of volunteer activities (Brudney & Nezhina, 2005; Hager & Brudney, 2004).

In order to maintain and improve volunteers' satisfaction from this motivation perspective, the volunteer recognition program is currently considered a vital management tool (Fisher & Ackerman, 1998; Jung & Nam, 2008). Volunteer recognition is generally described as an expression of gratitude or appreciation for volunteers' contributions (Fisher & Ackerman, 1998). The types of volunteer recognition can be categorized into intangible and tangible (Sue, 1996). The intangible volunteer recognition may be shown by expression of gratitude, while the tangible may take forms of small gifts, souvenirs, certificates, or awards. With a limited monetary compensation and career advancement, recognition rewards can play an important role as instrumental attributes that a nonprofit organization can offer for volunteers in the early stage of recruitment.

Brand personality as the symbolic attribute

A common approach to capture the symbolic attributes of a brand image is through the use of brand personality as it tends to serve as the self-expressive functions (Aaker, 1997). A key assumption of measuring organizational brand personality is the understanding that people can make an assessment of personality even if they have had limited exposure to the organization (Lievens & Highhouse, 2003; Slaughter, Zickar, Highhouse, & Mohr, 2004).

Applicants can easily associate human traits to an organization based on limited exposure to advertising media, corporate web sites, or recruitment materials (Highhouse, Thornbury, & Little, 2007; Lievens & Highhouse, 2003; Slaughter et al., 2004). Brand personalities can be shaped directly through the personality of the people associated with the organization, such as the CEO or endorsers. They can also be influenced indirectly by the brand name, symbols, logo, advertising style, distribution channel, and other product-related attributes (Plummer, 1985; Batra, Lehmann, & Singh, 1993).

Brand personality has been found as a predictor to consumers' psychological feelings toward a brand such as perceived brand quality, brand affect, brand trust, intimacy, satisfaction, and brand attachment (Aaker, Fournier, & Brasel, 2004; Lievens & Highhouse, 2003), which can ultimately influence general applicant attraction, intentions to pursue employment, perceptions of reputation, and the likelihood that applicants would accept job offers (Slaughter et al., 2004).

In response to the lack of agreement among scholars concerning how to measure brand personality, Aaker (1997) developed a framework of brand personality consisting of five dimensions: Sincerity, Excitement, Competence, Sophistication, and Ruggedness. Aaker's Brand Personality Inventory (BPI) is one of the most widely used tools for measuring brand personality and has been applied to a variety of industries.

Research suggests that applicants may draw inferences on organizational brand personality traits based on any information presented by the organization, such as the company's missions, employees or CEO, advertising practices, and brand associations such as brand name, symbol, logo, design, slogans, and distribution channel (Aaker, 1997; Batra et al., 1993). A study by Boudreaux and Palmer (2007) suggested the image, color, and layout displayed in a product can significantly affect perceived brand personality.

Labrecque and Milne (2012) conducted a study to figure out how different color influence how the consumers perceived brand personality. The study was constructed on the assumption that esthetic stimuli could potentially stimulate and shape people's perceptions through referential meaning (Zeltner, 1975). Another assumption in the study was the associative learning of visual information as a key mechanism for quick decision-making and survival, which develops during the early stage of visual processing (Schlack & Albright, 2007). The study found that there were positive relationships between the presented colors and brand personalities perceived by the participants. More specifically, the study showed that white and pink correlate with sincerity, red correlates with excitement; blue correlates with competence; purple, pink, and black correlate with sophistication, and brown correlates with ruggedness.

Beside the hue, Labrecque and Milne (2012) also found that the saturation and value of colors influence the perceived brand personality. Saturation is

the amount of pigment in color, measured on a scale from low (gray and washed out) to high (vivid), whereas value is the amount of lightness to darkness measure by a scale from low (black) to high (white). The study provided evidence that saturation has a positive relationship with excitement and ruggedness, as well as negative relationship with sophistication and sincerity, while value has a negative relationship with ruggedness and competence. Drawing on these findings, it is suggested that practitioners are able to manipulate the colors in their marketing strategies to create the intended brand personality.

In addition to color, research in psychology and design (e.g., Bartram, 1982; Lewis & Walker, 1989) supports that semantic associations can be derived from the physical characteristics of type fonts, and that the association linked to type font used in print advertisements are transferred to the brand (Childers & Jass, 2002). A study by Henderson, Giese, and Cote (2004) revealed four impression dimensions (pleasing/displeasing, engaging/boring, reassuring/unsettling, prominent/subtle) that may occur from various types of font design consisting of six factors (elaborateness, harmony, naturalness, flourish, weight, and compression).

Using the Henderson et al.'s (2004) results, Grohmann, Giese, and Parkman (2013) conducted a study to investigate the effect of different type font on the perceived brand personality. The results suggested that sincerity, excitement, and sophistication are enhanced when harmonious, natural, and flourish type fonts are used. Whereas ruggedness and competence perceptions increased with the use of harmonious, natural, heavy, and flourish type fonts. The results supported the framework of semantic influences of type font association that the font designs shape brand personality perceptions when consumers are unfamiliar with the brand.

Hypotheses development

As previously described, job/organizational characteristics are strong predictors of organizational attractiveness. In profit-oriented companies, these characteristics can be easily derived to salary, incentives, benefits, positions, career opportunities, organizational structure, size, and work location (Cable & Graham, 2000; Lievens et al., 2001). For non-profit organizations, the job/organizational characteristics are limited as there are neither monetary compensations nor career advancement opportunities for the volunteers. Consequently, NPOs clearly have disadvantages in regards to attracting volunteers compared to profit companies. However, this does not necessarily mean that nonprofits do not have any instrumental aspect to offer to the volunteering candidates. As previously explained, recognition rewards can play an important role as instrumental attributes that a nonprofit organization can offer for volunteers in the early stage of recruitment.

Despite many studies that have provided evidence regarding the effect of recognition reward on volunteer satisfaction and continuity (e.g., Fisher & Ackerman, 1998; Jung & Nam, 2008; Lee & Jung, 2006), there is a dearth of research investigating the effect of recognition reward to the attractiveness of the organization during the recruiting process. Therefore, part of this study is conducted to examine the relationship between recognition reward as the instrumental aspect of the brand image and the intent to volunteer. For practicality consideration, recognition reward in this study is operationalized as the tangible reward in the form of the certificate of appreciation offered in the recruitment advertisement. Considering that recognition reward positively influence volunteer satisfaction and continuity of volunteer activities (Fisher & Ackerman, 1998; Jung, 2011), we derive the following hypothesis:

H1: There is a significant difference on the intent to volunteer between potential applicants who are offered a recognition reward and who are not offered any recognition reward.

As the symbolic attribute of organizational brand image, brand personality holds an important role in influencing consumers' psychological feelings toward the organization, including the applicant's intention to apply and decision during recruitment (Aaker et al., 2004; Cable & Turban, 2001; Lemmink et al., 2003; Lievens & Highhouse, 2003). Aaker (1997) developed a framework of brand personality comprises of five dimensions (excitement, competence, sincerity, ruggedness, sophistication), with each dimension influences brand attractiveness differently. However, most of the studies in regards to the relationship between brand personality and attractiveness in nonprofit settings are rarely explained. Therefore, this study also investigates the following hypothesis:

H2: There are significant differences on the intent to volunteer among potential applicants exposed to each of the five brand personality dimensions compared to potential applicants who are not exposed to any brand personalities.

Research about brand personality found that each dimension in Aaker's BPI may have a different impact on potential applicants. Lievens and Highhouse (2003) found that "innovation" (equivalent to "excitement") and "competence" plays more important role in attracting applicants. Further, they explained that pursuing a job in an organization that is considered to be innovative or competent enables them to express parts of their self-concept and personality that are held in high regards by others. A study by Zentes, Morschett, and Schramm-Klein (2008) confirmed that "competence," "sincerity," and "excitement" were three most influential traits positively affecting consumer's loyalty, and among them "sincerity" has the strongest influence.

Another study on brand personality was conducted by Rampl and Kenning (2014), which provided empirical support for a significant correlation between several brand personality traits and employer brand affect and trust. The study showed that “sincerity” has a significant effect on both employer brand trust and affect, due to an effect of feeling secure when dealing with a sincere employer organization. The study also found that Excitement and ruggedness both had a greater effect on brand affect, since they may be particularly useful for eliciting emotions associated with a specific employer brand. However, the effect of ruggedness was surprisingly negative, indicating lower levels of positive brand affect with increased ruggedness perceptions. This result may be specific for employer brands, because ruggedness may indicate an organization with much competition and tough consequences for an employee’s everyday work life, resulting in less positive affect. On the other hand, the study found that “sophistication” had a significant effect on brand affect, but no significant effect on brand trust. In contrary to Lievens and Highhouse’s (2003) findings, Rampl and Kenning (2014) found that the brand personality trait of competence was not a significant predictor of either brand affect or brand trust. Potentially, the effect of competence is specific to the industry and functions investigated, which was a consultancy. The weak influence may be due to the fact that consultancies are commonly characterized by high proficiency (Fink & Knoblach, 2011). In nonprofit settings, competence dimension may not be significant due to the nature of the job that usually does not require specific competencies. From these findings, the following hypothesis is proposed:

H3: The organization brand personalities of “sincerity” and “excitement” have stronger effects on the applicant’s’ intent to volunteer than those of “competence”, “sophistication”, and “ruggedness”.

Since both instrumental and symbolic attributes influence the creation of the organizational brand image, it is possible that there is an interaction effect between the recognition reward as the instrumental function and brand personality as the symbolic function in predicting the intent to volunteer of the potential applicants. Therefore, we hypothesize:

H4: There is an interaction effect between brand personality and recognition reward on the intent to volunteer.

Method

The purpose of this study is to examine the effect of nonprofit organizations’ brand image, which constitutes brand personality as the symbolic function and recognition reward as the instrumental function, on college students’

intent to volunteer. This research is divided into two parts. Study 1 was conducted using survey technique with a purpose to develop the instrument that will be used for the experiment. Study 2 is the main experimental study that was conducted to test the four hypotheses. The independent variables are recognition reward and brand personality. The dependent variable is the intention to volunteer. The methods of this study including research design, instruments, participants, procedures, and the statistical analysis are described below.

Participants

The participants in both parts of the study were selected using a snowball availability sampling approach using social media such as Facebook, online newsletters, and email requests from student populations in The United States. In all, 250 college students participated, with 117 participated in study 1 and 133 participated in study 2.

Design and instruments

An explanatory quantitative design with surveys and experimental techniques were used in this research. More details on the instruments are described below.

Demographics

The participants were asked to fill in their gender, age, and year in school (freshman, sophomore, junior, senior, or graduate) to describe the demographic characteristics.

Brand personality

This construct serves as the symbolic attribute and the first independent variable (IV). Aaker's (1997) brand personality inventory (BPI) was used in study 1 to measure brand personality dimensions representativeness of each self-developed brand. The original inventory consists of 42 items rated on a 7-point Likert scale concerning the ability to describe a brand's characteristics. High levels of reliability were found in every dimensions: sincerity = .93, excitement = .95, competence = .93, sophistication = .91, and ruggedness = .90. In the attempt to increase participation rate, we used the shortened version with 15 items that has been proven reliable (Orth & Malkewitz, 2008). In study 2, the five brands developed in study 1 were used to represent the five brand personality dimensions.

Recognition reward

This variable serves as the instrumental attribute and the second IV. Each group received both the advertisement that offers no reward and another advertisement that offers a recognition reward. The recognition reward was offered in the form of appreciation certificate.

Intention to volunteer

The applicant's intention to volunteer was measured with a one-item survey rated on a 7-point Likert scale. The item shows after each recruitment advertisement of the NPOs was presented. Volunteer intention is the dependent variable (DV) of the study.

Procedures

Study 1: development of the brand personality instrument

Before administering the main study, a study to assess the representativeness of the brand personalities on the instrument needed to be conducted. First, researchers developed five NPO brands and slogans to represent each dimension of brand personality from Aaker's framework (1997). The brands were developed from existing brands that are perceived as rugged, exciting, sincere, sophisticated, and competent. Past research on color and type font (Labrecque & Milne, 2012; Ridgway, 2011; Henderson et al., 2004; Grohmann et al., 2012) were used as the criteria to choose the visual representatives of the brands associated with each personality. Each brand then modified partially to prevent participants associating the brands with existing organizations.

Then, each participant received an email with the link to an online survey platform and was randomly assigned into one of the five groups. In each group, participants were shown one brand, and then they were asked to rate how strong that brand describes the traits chosen from Aaker's Brand Personality Inventory.

Study 2: hypotheses testing

This study is the main part of the research, in which the four hypotheses were tested. For this part of the study, the participants were assigned into six groups randomly using excel software. Their names were arranged in a single column in a systematic order and then we created a second column of random numbers generated by the RAND() function and sort them by those random numbers. Once the randomizations were done, we then sent each of them an email with a link to the surveys in an online survey platform. The first five groups were exposed to both the symbolic and instrumental attribute of the brand image, whereas the one control group was not exposed to the full brand image.

Group A, B, C, D, and E were exposed to recruitment advertisements with one different organizational brand for each group, while group F was exposed to recruitment advertisements without any organizational brand. All six groups were given two advertisements with one advertisement offers a certificate as the recognition reward, and one does not offer a certificate. After the advertisement of each organization, the participants in all groups were asked to rate how much they want to volunteer for that organization.

Statistical analysis

For study 1, a one-way ANOVA was used to identify whether or not the targeted traits have higher rates than the other traits. For study 2, a two-way-mixed ANOVA and follow-up contrast test for the within-group factor were utilized to analyze the data and test the hypotheses. T-tests were also conducted to check the balance of the covariates (age, gender, and level of study) between the control group and the treatment groups.

Hypothesis 1 examines the statistical difference in the intent to volunteer between potential applicants who were offered recognition reward and potential applicants who were not offered recognition reward. To test this hypothesis, a repeated measure or within-group comparison using t-test was conducted with recognition reward as the IV and intent to volunteer as DV.

Hypothesis 2 proposed statistical differences in the intent to volunteer among potential applicants exposed to the five brand personality dimensions. A between-group ANOVA was conducted to test this hypothesis with brand personality as the IV and intent to volunteer as DV.

Hypothesis 3 proposed that sincerity and excitement have stronger effects on the applicant's intent to volunteer than competence, sophistication, and ruggedness. To test this hypothesis, the follow-up contrast tests were utilized.

Hypothesis 4 examines the interaction effects between brand personalities and recognition reward on the intent to volunteer. The interaction effect was analyzed using the ANOVA results. The estimated marginal means were also used to determine the nature of the interaction.

Results

This chapter includes the description of the sample and the demographic profile, the ANOVA results for study 1 and representativeness of the brands used on the instrument, as well as the ANOVA results for study 2 that tested the four hypotheses.

Sample characteristics

Study 1

For the first part of the study, a total of 117 participants were recruited. Participants consisted of 63 (53.8%) females and 52 (44.4%) males. Two percent of the participants preferred not to disclose their gender. The age of the participants ranged from 18 to 44 years old, with 39.3% of them were between the ages of 18–24, 53.8% of them were 25–34 years old, and 6.8% of them were 35–44 years old.

Study 2

A total of 133 college students participated in the second part of the study. Among these, 43.6% were males, 55.6% were females, and .8% did not disclose their gender. Consistent with the previous part of the study, the age of the participants ranged from 18 to 44 years old. More specifically, 46.6% were 18–24 years old, 42.9% were 25–34 years old, and 10.5% were 35–44 years old. There was no significant difference between the control group and the treatment groups in terms of age and gender. The table showing means differences and the balance tests are shown in table 3.1.

Results of study 1

A one-way ANOVA was conducted to test the representativeness of the brands used on the brand personality instrument. Each brand was analyzed using a repeated-measure ANOVA, and the results showed significant differences between most of the targeted traits and the other traits.

The first brand was aimed to represent competence. The result showed a significant difference between the traits from competence facet (intelligent, competent) and the other traits ($F(4, 150) = 5.814, p = .000, r = .39$). Post hoc tests revealed that the competence traits are rated significantly higher than all of the other traits. The results indicating this can be found in Table 3.2, Table 3.3, and Figure 3.1.

The second brand was targeted to represent sincerity. The results showed a significant difference between the traits from sincerity facet (genuine, sincere) and most of the other traits ($F(4, 95) = 7.262, p = .000, r = .55$). Post hoc tests revealed that the sincerity traits are rated higher than all of the other traits, and significantly higher than ruggedness. The results indicating this can be found in Table 3.4, Table 3.5, and Figure 3.1.

The third brand was aimed to represent excitement. The result showed a significant difference between the traits from excitement facet (exciting, spirited) and most of the other traits ($F(4, 110) = 6.397, p = .000, r = .48$). Post hoc tests revealed that the excitement traits are rated higher than

ruggedness, and significantly higher than all of the other three. The results indicating this can be found in Table 3.6, Table 3.7, and Figure 3.1.

The fourth brand was developed to represent ruggedness. The result showed a significant difference between the traits from ruggedness facet (masculine, rugged) and most of the other traits ($F(4, 95) = 4.745, p = .002, r = 0.45$). Post hoc tests revealed that the ruggedness traits are rated higher than competence and excitement, and significantly higher than sincerity and sophistication. The results indicating this can be found in Table 3.8, Table 3.9, and Figure 3.1.

The fifth brand was targeted to represent sophistication. The result showed a significant difference between the traits from sophistication facet (charming, sophisticated) and most of the other traits ($F(4, 110) = 9.372, p = .000, r = .58$). Post hoc tests revealed that the sophistication traits are rated higher than sincerity and excitement, and significantly higher than competence and ruggedness. The results indicating this can be found in Table 3.10, Table 3.11, and Figure 3.1.

Based on these results, all the targeted traits are rated higher than the other traits. Although not all the differences are significant, the statistical differences were observable. Moreover, the effect sizes of all the differences were relatively large ($>.37$), which means that the effect of the brands largely contributed to the traits perceived. According to Cohen's (1988) guidelines, an effect size is considered small at .1, medium at .24, and large at .37. Therefore, we concluded that all the brands were representative and ready to be used for the main study.

Results of study 2

The second part of the study was conducted to test the four hypotheses proposed. A two-way-mixed ANOVA and follow-up contrast test for the within-group factor were utilized to analyze the data.

Hypothesis 1 posited that there is a significant difference in the intent to volunteer between potential applicants who are offered a recognition reward and who are not offered any recognition reward. The test of within-subject showed a significant difference between the two groups ($F(1, 254) = 10.04, p = .002$), which supported the hypothesis. The descriptive statistics are depicted in Table 3.12.

The ANOVA also provided support for hypothesis 2 ($F(5, 254) = 9.09, p = .000$), which proposed that there are significant differences on the intent to volunteer among potential applicants exposed to each of the five brand personality dimensions compared to potential applicants who are not exposed to any brand personalities. Compared to the control group, all the groups with visual representatives of the brand scored significantly higher on the intent to volunteer. These results are presented in Table 3.13 and 3.14.

Hypothesis 3 proposed that sincerity and excitement have stronger effects on the applicant's' intent to volunteer than competence, sophistication, and ruggedness. The survey showed that the intention to volunteer score for the sincerity brand was the highest compared to the other brands. However, none of the differences were significant. Similarly, the excitement brand was not significantly different than the others. These results did not fully support hypothesis 3. The results also showed no interaction effect between recognition rewards and brand personality, which rejected hypothesis 4. These results are presented in Figure 3.2.

Discussion

This chapter discusses the major findings in regards to the theories and past research. The implications and contributions of the findings are also described in this chapter, as well as the limitations and suggestions for future research.

Discussion of findings

The findings of this study supported hypothesis 1 and 2. These results showed that both instrumental and symbolic aspects of the organization that were presented in the recruitment advertisements influenced the intention to volunteer on college students. More specifically, hypothesis 1 supported the importance of recognition reward as the instrumental attribute, while hypothesis 2 supported the importance of brand personality as the symbolic attribute.

These results were consistent with previous studies that showed the influence of brand image on the potential applicants' intention to apply in profit-oriented companies (e.g., Aaker et al., 2004; Cable & Graham, 2000; Lievens et al., 2001; Lievens & Highhouse, 2003). Therefore, this study provides empirical evidence that the roles of brand image in recruitment process can be extended to non-profit settings. It can be suggested that brand image for a non-profit organization is important in the volunteer recruitment process, as it is important in employee recruitment for profit-oriented organizations.

The support for hypothesis 1 was evidence that recognition reward influences college students' intention to volunteer. It has been found in previous studies that additional benefits from volunteer activities such as recognition and appreciation might influence the continuity of volunteer activities (Fisher & Ackerman, 1998) and improve volunteers' satisfaction (Jung, 2011; Jung & Nam, 2008). The results of this study extend the impact of recognition rewards. It can be seen from this study that not only influencing continuity and volunteer satisfaction, recognition rewards was also found to be contributing to attracting volunteers.

Further, hypothesis 2 was supported in this study. It expands to nonprofits the notion that brand personality can be a predictor to the applicants' psychological

feelings that can ultimately influence general applicants attraction and intention to apply for the job (Aaker et al., 2004; Lievens & Highhouse, 2003; Slaughter et al., 2004). The results showed that applicants preferred to volunteer for organizations that showed at least the idea of their personalities through the brand logo and slogans, compared to the organizations that did not show its personality at all. This is also consistent with past research that showed companies with the strong brand image would be preferred over those with weak or negative brand image (Cable & Turban, 2001).

However, the results of this study did not reveal any interaction between the instrumental and symbolic function. This means that the recognition reward as the instrumental attribute has the same effect no matter what the brand personality is. Vice versa, the existence of a brand personality impacts the intention to volunteer whether or not the applicants are offered the recognition reward. In other words, the impact of each attribute is independent of one another.

The surveys showed that the participants were more willing to volunteer for organizations that presented the brand personalities through the brand logo and slogans, compared to the organizations without any presented brand personalities. However, significant differences among the five types of brand personality were not found. The results did show that the volunteer intentions were higher for the organization with the brand personality of sincerity, which could partially support hypothesis 3, but the differences in the other personalities were not significant. This was not consistent with previous research that showed the different effect of different brand personalities (e.g., Lievens & Highhouse, 2003; Rampl & Kenning, 2014; Zentes et al., 2008).

The results of these non-significant differences might occur because all the different types of brand personality gave about the same impact to the participants, or it might also cause by the inadequate personalities of each brand presented on the instrument. In this study, the brand personalities are perceived only from the logos and slogans presented in the ads, while in reality, brand personalities are not only perceived by them. Another possible cause of the non-significant results was the confounding variable that might have occurred during the process of study 1. The brands that were used in this study were taken from real-life brands. Some participants might be familiar with the actual companies producing those brands. Thus, their intention to volunteer might also be caused by their perception of the actual companies. More details on this issue are discussed in the limitation section.

Theoretical and practical implications

Theoretical implication

Most of the researchers on the organizational brand image have focused on its influence on potential applicants for jobs in profit-oriented organizations. The findings of this study contribute to expanding the body of knowledge

regarding brand image and intention to apply for volunteering positions in non-profit settings. This study used the instrumental-symbolic framework to explain the brand image, which enriches the results of the study. According to this framework, instrumental and symbolic attributes contribute to form the perception of the brand image, and the findings of this study showed that both of the attributes influence the intent to volunteer. This supports the notion that brand image is an important variable that influences the outcome of a recruitment process.

The results of study 1 contribute to the research that relates to color, font, and slogans of a brand and the relations to the perceived brand personalities. Following the findings from past research, the colors of the logos presented in this study were blue for competence, green for sincerity, red for excitement, brown for ruggedness, and black for sophistication. The font types used were high on weight and harmony and low on elaborate for competence; high on natural, harmony, and flourish for sincerity; high on elaborate, natural, and flourish for excitement; high on natural and flourish and low on weight for sophistication; and high on weight and flourish for ruggedness. All the slogans presented to the participants included at least one synonym word from each brand personality facet. Since not all the results were significant, a conclusion that different colors, font types, and slogans presented on the recruitment advertisements influenced the ratings on traits associated with the organizations could not be made. However, some of the results showed significant differences. For example, the traits in competence facet were rated significantly higher than the other traits when the participants were presented a brand with the color blue and a certain font type that was low on design factor elaborate and high on design factor weight and harmony. These results show that the participants perceived different types of personality only from the logo and slogans, supporting the assumption that people can make an assessment of personality even if they have had limited exposure to the organization (Lievens & Highhouse, 2003; Slaughter et al., 2004). Nevertheless, further research with bigger sample size is recommended to validate this assumption for all types of brand personalities.

Practical implication

The results of this study provide empirical support for the importance of brand image, including recognition reward and brand personalities, in the recruitment process for volunteering positions in non-profit organizations. These findings suggest that non-profit practitioners should consider all the instrumental and symbolic factors of the organization's brand image when advertising their volunteering opportunities.

Since NPOs have limited instrumental benefits such as pay and career advancement, a simple certificate of appreciation or other forms of recognition rewards offered in the recruitment ads might be helpful to attract more people.

Providing recognition rewards do not take a high budget, and it shows potential applicants that the organization cares and appreciates them for their time and efforts. This could be an efficient way that non-profit practitioners can do to increase their volunteers without sacrificing a high cost.

This study also suggests that non-profit practitioners should take into account the brand personality of their organization and show it to the potential applicants at least visually through the brand logo and verbally through the slogan. As explained in the past research, the presentation of the brand in the organization's promotional activities can shape the volunteer candidates' attitudes toward the organization and influence their actions, including their intention to apply for volunteering activities (Bendapudi et al., 1996). The recruitment advertisement can be one of the media that practitioners can use to present their brand personalities, but in reality, they can also use other ways to show the organizations' brand personalities such as through the people (CEO, endorsers), advertising styles, symbols, or other product-related attributes.

Limitations and future research

This study has several limitations. First, the study used visual cues based on color and type font to represent brand personalities. As explained earlier, brand personalities can be shaped not only from the visual cues on the recruitment ads, but also directly through the personality of the people associated with the organization and indirectly through the brand name, symbols, logo, advertising style, distribution channel, and other product-related attributes (Aaker, 1997; Plummer, 1985; Batra et al., 1993). Although there are empirical supports that color and font type influence people's perception of brand personalities (e.g., Labrecque & Milne, 2012; Grohmann et al., 2012), the effect might not be powerful. The non-significant differences on the perceived traits were consistent with this notion. As discussed in the discussion section, this might influence the observed differences of the intent to volunteer among different brand personalities. The non-significant differences observed in the results might be caused by the inadequate personalities of each brand that only came from the logos and slogans.

Moreover, it is possible that a confounding effect distorted the results of the study. As explained in the discussion section, some of the brands might look too similar to the original brands, and the participants might be influenced by their perception of the actual organizations. For example, brand 3 was derived from a soft drink product. The participants might not be willing to volunteer not because of the brand personality perceived from the logo and slogans presented in the study, but because of the image of the soft drink company that they already had. This might explain why the intent

to volunteer for brands with competence and excitement were rated lower than the other brand personalities. It is possible that they were rated lower because of the prior perception about the original organizations. Therefore, future studies displaying stronger brand personalities involving other factors would be helpful to get more comprehensive results on the effect of each type of brand personality on volunteering intention.

Second, the results of this study might not be generalizable for populations across cultures, since all participants are college students in the USA. As pointed out by Aaker (1997) herself, the concept of brand personality may not remain robust in different cultures because of the antecedents. Additionally, the effect of color as one of the antecedents of the brand personalities may be different from culture to culture. Future research is needed to examine the extent to which the effect of color and type font on brand personalities and the effect of brand personalities on the volunteering intentions are stable across cultures.

Third, this study used Aaker's brand personality framework as the symbolic attribute. However, Venable, Rose, Bush, and Gilbert (2005) have developed a framework of brand personality for nonprofits, which has several differences with Aaker's that were developed using profit-oriented companies. The nonprofit brand personality framework consists of four dimensions: integrity, ruggedness, sophistication, and nurturance. The empirical supports of this framework are not as comprehensive as Aaker's, especially regarding visual attributes such as color and type font. However, for future research, utilizing Venable et al.'s framework might be a better fit for the nonprofit settings.

Related to the methodology, some limitations arose due to the small sample size. Experimental technique was used in order to test the score differences among control group and all other groups with manipulated IVs, participants were divided into these groups, thus more sample should be used to gain an adequate statistical power. The non-significant results in this study might have occurred not because there was no effect, but simply because of the sample size. Additionally, the participants were recruited using a snowball availability sampling approach online. The students who were voluntarily participated might not be representative of all students in the USA.

Furthermore, the results of this study should be interpreted cautiously. Readers must keep in mind that the dependent variable in this study was the intent to volunteer, which was not a behavioral outcome. A potential volunteer might have an intention to volunteer, but in reality, does not actually apply for the job. Other factors should be taken into consideration when connecting the intent to volunteer and the behavior of volunteering itself.

As a result of conducting this research, it can be concluded that incorporating both component of brand image in recruiting volunteer is

advantageous for nonprofit organizations. Based on the results, recognition reward as the instrumental attribute affects the intent to volunteer, thus can be utilized to attract more volunteers. However, this study shows significant results for several brand personalities yet non-significant results for several others. Further research is necessary to validate the effect of brand personality to the intent to volunteer. More research is also needed to investigate the interaction between the instrumental and symbolic attributes, as well as the effect of these attributes to other variables related to volunteering behavior in nonprofit organizations.

Disclosure statement

No potential conflict of interest was reported by the authors.

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